

The Autological Structure of Truth

Why $T \equiv R$ Is the Only Theory That Survives Self-Application

Erik Xander Harvard

Independent Researcher

Erik.Harvard@proton.me

erikxanderharvard.com

May 2026

Abstract

Truth is not correspondence, coherence, pragmatism, consensus, deflationism, or a T-schema. It is reality, self-disclosed. This essay demands that any theory of truth be true by its own criterion—and it applies that demand here, now, to itself. Six theories fail the demand. One survives: $T \equiv R$. The proof is not an argument about reality. It is reality, arguing. This sentence exists. Its existence is not separate from its truth. They are the same reality. What follows is the argument, enacting itself.

Keywords: identity theory of truth, autological criterion, self-application, correspondence theory, propositional realism, $T \equiv R$, metaontology

Introduction

This essay is true by its own criterion, or it fails before it begins.

A theory of truth that cannot satisfy its own definition of truth has already refuted itself—directly, and from within.

The criterion is not imposed from outside; it is what any claim to know what truth is already demands. This is not a standard selectively applied to one's opponents. For truth specifically—not for theories of mass, or of causation, or of number—the demand for self-application is internal to the concept itself. To claim knowledge of truth is to make a truth-claim. That truth-claim must satisfy whatever truth is. If it cannot, the theory is not merely incomplete; it is self-eliminating at the moment of its assertion. No external tribunal is required. The tribunal is the act of claiming.

A predicate is *autological* if it applies to itself: “short” is a short word. A predicate is *heterological* if it does not: “long” is not a long word. Applied to theories of truth: an autological theory satisfies its own criterion of truth. A heterological theory does not—and a theory of truth that fails its own criterion self-refutes, or excludes itself from its own scope. Heterology, for a theory of truth, is not failure. It is self-elimination. The route differs—some theories apply to themselves and fail their own criterion (by regress, circularity, or performative contradiction), some dissolve into a rival under examination, some are structurally incapable of self-application by design—but the failure is the same: the theory cannot satisfy the criterion it proposes as truth.

For any theory that defines truth as a property P : does the theory itself possess P ? If yes, the theory is autological. If no, it is heterological—and therefore self-eliminated. If one theory alone is autological among all competitors, that theory is not merely the best answer. It is the only possible one.

$$\text{AC: } \mathcal{T} \models_{\text{sat}} P(\mathcal{T}) \Leftrightarrow \mathcal{T} \text{ is autological; } \mathcal{T} \not\models_{\text{sat}} P(\mathcal{T}) \Leftrightarrow \mathcal{T} \text{ is heterological}$$

where $\models_{\text{sat}}$ denotes satisfaction: $\mathcal{T}$ satisfies $P(\mathcal{T})$ when, submitted as an object under its own truth-criterion, it possesses the property P that criterion defines. This is not metalogical entailment but first-order self-application: the theory is placed under its own standard and asked whether it passes.

Six theories face this test. These are the historically dominant accounts of truth—not claimed to be exhaustive of every possible account, but representative of every major structural type: *relational accounts* (truth fixed by a match between proposition and external fact: correspondence); *systemic accounts* (truth fixed by coherence within a belief-structure: coherence theory); *instrumental accounts* (truth fixed by practical or epistemic outcomes: pragmatism); *epistemically convergent accounts* (truth fixed by idealized inquiry or consensus); *formal-hierarchical accounts* (truth fixed by predicate levels in a metalanguage: Tarski); and *minimalist accounts* (truth a non-substantive logical operator on propositions: deflationism). Putnam’s internal realism—truth as idealized rational acceptability—falls under the epistemically convergent category; its AC failure is structurally identical to the consensus theory’s: the claim that truth is what ideally rational inquiry would accept is itself a claim whose truth does not depend on what ideally rational inquiry would accept.

Pluralist accounts (Wright: distinct truth properties for distinct discourse domains) are not here eliminated by a single AC application but by an iterative one. Wright holds that superassertibility, for instance, may be the truth property for moral discourse. Does the claim “superassertibility is truth for moral discourse” satisfy its own criterion? If it is true by superassertibility, it must be superassertible—ideally assertible under conditions of warranted inquiry. But whether that metaclaim is superassertible requires a further domain-level criterion to adjudicate, and so on. Each domain-local autological closure, if achieved, achieves it only within a domain whose boundaries are fixed by a further fact not available from within the domain—precisely the independence-condition that drives every other theory to dissolution. No domain-local autological closure is stable without an extra-domain ground. The elimination argument applies iteratively across every domain

Wright posits; no domain-specific truth property achieves genuine autological closure without importing the conditions $T \equiv R$ alone satisfies globally. Wright may respond that the meta-claim is a philosophical claim, assessed by philosophical standards rather than by the moral-domain criterion itself. But this concedes that a universal criterion for philosophical truth is presupposed. That universal criterion must itself be autological or heterological: if autological, it satisfies $T \equiv R$ globally; if heterological, it self-eliminates. In neither case does domain-pluralism escape the elimination. The retreat to philosophical standards reinstates the global question the pluralist sought to dissolve.

Primitivist accounts—truth as a brute, underivable ground requiring no further analysis—are addressed directly in §VII. All six canonical theories are heterological. One is autological—not by surviving a test applied from outside, but by being the test, passing itself, from within.

I. Correspondence

Correspondence holds that a proposition¹ is true when it corresponds to a fact. Aristotle: to say of what is that it is, is true. Russell, Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* (whose picture theory holds that propositions share logical form with facts, a structural variant of correspondence), and the logical atomists concur. Reality, on this view, is the totality of such facts; the proposition must match one of them.

The claim is: truth is correspondence to a fact.

For this claim to be true, it must itself correspond to a fact—the fact that truth is correspondence. This is not merely an epistemological difficulty about how one would verify such a claim. The problem is ontological. For the correspondence relation to obtain between this claim and that fact, a prior instance of the correspondence relation must already hold; the obtaining of correspondence requires a prior obtaining. The regress is in the order of being: correspondence must obtain, and its obtaining requires a prior obtaining, without terminus. No position exists outside the claim and the world from which the relation is secured—because any such position would itself require a further correspondence to obtain.

$$\mathcal{T}_{\text{corr}} \not\models_{\text{sat}} P_{\text{corr}}(\mathcal{T}_{\text{corr}}) \quad (\text{AC})$$

What correspondence tries to bridge, it creates.

II. Coherence

Coherence holds that truth is coherence within a system of beliefs. Bradley, Blanshard: a proposition is true when it fits, consistently and comprehensively, within everything else one believes.

¹Throughout this essay, *proposition* designates a truth-apt content individuated by what it presents, not by its linguistic or psychological vehicle. A full treatment of the term appears in §VII.

The claim is: truth is coherence. Is it coherent? Yes. It fits within a coherentist epistemology without contradiction.

But coherence does not, without further specification, discriminate. A perfectly consistent mythology is coherent. A self-sealing delusion—in which every belief supports every other, no external check is admitted, the system is complete—is coherent. A fantasy world whose internal logic is flawless is coherent. On the simple coherence criterion, all three qualify as true—which reveals that the criterion requires supplementation, as the sophisticated coherentist concedes.

All three cannot be true—and coherence alone cannot say which one is. The coherentist may respond that only the maximally comprehensive coherent system qualifies. But fixing a unique true comprehensive system ($\exists! \mathcal{S}^*$) requires an independent fact about which system actually obtains—a fact not available within any coherent system, and a fact that just is what the correspondence theory requires. In completing itself, coherentism must import the independence-condition it was designed to deny.

$$P_{\text{coh}}(\mathcal{T}_{\text{coh}}) \wedge \left(\exists! \mathcal{S}^* \xrightarrow{\text{ind. fact}_{\text{def}}} P_{\text{corr}} \right) \Rightarrow \mathcal{T}_{\text{coh}} \not\models_{\text{sat}} P_{\text{coh}} \quad (\text{AC})$$

Coherence cannot exclude its rivals without becoming what it denies.

III. Pragmatism

Pragmatism holds that truth is what works. James: true ideas are those we can assimilate, validate, corroborate, and verify. Dewey's more disciplined version—"warranted assertibility"—grounds success not in bare utility but in the controlled outcomes of rigorous inquiry. The refinement is genuine, but it deepens rather than escapes the problem. Even warranted assertibility requires a prior criterion to determine what counts as genuine warrant: which methods of inquiry are rigorous, which outcomes genuine, which assertions actually supported. That criterion cannot come from pragmatism itself without circularity. Dewey cannot invoke "inquiry works" as warrant without presupposing a standard of rigor not itself derived from the outcomes of inquiry.

$$\mathcal{T}_{\text{prag}} \not\models_{\text{sat}} P_{\text{prag}}(\mathcal{T}_{\text{prag}}) \quad (\text{AC})$$

The circle does not touch ground.

IV. Consensus

Consensus holds that truth is what ideally rational inquirers would agree upon at the end of inquiry under conditions of undistorted communication. Peirce, in "How to Make Our Ideas Clear,"

argues that inquiry converges toward a final opinion as its truth. Habermas grounds truth in ideal discourse free from domination and distortion.

This essay does not agree that truth is consensus.

The essay's claim depends on no agreement. If that claim is true, it is true because of what it says and whether it obtains—not because philosophers converge on it.

The theory cannot be stated without being violated. To assert “truth is consensus” is to make a truth-claim whose truth does not depend on consensus. Every philosopher who has defended the consensus theory has done so by presenting arguments, not by waiting for agreement. The theory's own defenders refute it in the act of defending it.

$$\mathcal{T}_{\text{con}} \not\models_{\text{sat}} P_{\text{con}}(\mathcal{T}_{\text{con}}) \quad (\text{AC})$$

Consensus self-refutes in the act of utterance.

V. Deflationism

Deflationism holds that “true” is not a substantive predicate. Ramsey: “It is true that Caesar was murdered” means no more than “Caesar was murdered.” Horwich extends this: the truth predicate endorses rather than ascribes.

Deflationism claims the truth predicate is non-substantive. This assertion is itself substantive. Horwich's minimalism attempts to retreat: the theory is not a claim about truth-as-a-property, it is a claim about the logical behaviour of the predicate—its disquotational function. But a claim about the logical behaviour of a predicate is itself a claim that is true or false; the truth of that meta-claim is not exhausted by any instance of the disquotational schema. It is a substantive semantic fact about the predicate. In stating it, deflationism makes precisely the kind of claim it declares impossible. The inconsistency is not in the theory's content but in the act of asserting it. Every statement of deflationism is a counterexample to deflationism.

$$\mathcal{T}_{\text{defl}} \not\models_{\text{sat}} P_{\text{defl}}(\mathcal{T}_{\text{defl}}) \quad (\text{AC})$$

To say that truth adds nothing is to say something. The saying is not nothing.

VI. Tarski's Semantic Conception

Of all candidates, Tarski's T-schema is the most formally rigorous: “*P*” is true if and only if *P*. “Snow is white” is true if and only if snow is white. The schema is materially adequate, generating

all and only the correct instances. It is formally correct, avoiding the Liar paradox by requiring that the truth predicate for any language L be defined only within a metalanguage that properly contains L .

This is the failure.

Tarski's theory cannot be stated in the language it governs. To define truth for the metalanguage requires a meta-metalanguage. To define truth for that requires another level. The hierarchy has no terminus. Tarski acknowledged this as the correct result: the theory was never intended to apply to languages containing their own truth predicate. It cannot apply its own truth predicate to itself.

Tarski's formal elegance is purchased at the price of self-application. The avoidance of paradox and the avoidance of completeness are the same avoidance. The theory is consistent only because it excludes itself from its own scope. Why does this hierarchy never arise for $T \equiv R$? Because the hierarchy is necessary only when truth is posited as a relation between a proposition and a domain it stands over against. Eliminate the gap between proposition and reality, and there is no domain to ascend above. The metalanguage regress is not an inevitable feature of any theory of truth; it is the structural consequence of a gap that the Identity Theory does not share.

$$\mathcal{T}_{\text{Tarski}} \not\models_{\text{sat}} P_{\text{Tarski}}(\mathcal{T}_{\text{Tarski}}) \quad (\text{AC})$$

A theory of truth that cannot speak of its own truth is not a complete theory of truth.

VII. The Identity Theory: $T \equiv R$

Six failures. One structure. Each theory required something beyond itself to establish its own truth—and no such thing exists. The problem is the gap. The specific gap differs—proposition and fact, belief-system and independent actuality, method and warrant, discourse and ideal consensus, predicate and content, language and metalanguage—but the structure is constant: each theory posits truth as fixed by reference to a standard external to the truth-bearer itself. The regress, dissolution, or exclusion in each case is the consequence of that structure, not of the specific content of the theory. Eliminate the structure, and all six failures are eliminated at once.

There is no gap.

$$\boxed{T \equiv R}$$

Truth is not a relational property propositions acquire by standing in the right relation to something external. Truth *is* reality. The distinction between identity ($\equiv$) and equivalence ($\sim$) is not notational. Equivalence is system-relative: it says two items, evaluated within a common frame, have the same value under some measure. Identity is ontological: it says two terms designate the same entity—not the same value under some measure, but the same thing, indivisibly. The distinction between numerical and qualitative identity is standard: two things can be qualitatively identical (exactly alike) while remaining numerically distinct (two entities, not one). $T \equiv R$ is a claim of numerical identity: truth and reality are not two items found to be equivalent under some measure; they are one thing reached by two names. Williamson's logic of absolute identity establishes that numerical identity admits no degrees and tolerates no relativisation—when two terms are absolutely identical, no relation between them is possible or needed, because there are not two relata. Here truth is not a predicate whose extension is fixed by a truth-condition external to the proposition; it is the ontological domain—the totality of what exists—and the identity claim says that domain and the extension of the truth-predicate are one and the same. This dissolves the gap correspondence tried to bridge. $T \equiv R$ is not a stronger version of correspondence; it is its negation.

Throughout this essay, *proposition* designates a truth-apt content defined by what it presents—not by its linguistic vehicle, its mental occurrence, or its syntactic form. A proposition is the minimal unit of truth-bearing: whatever it is whose identity is constitutively a matter of what it presents as being the case. This is consistent with Fregean and Russellian approaches alike, and deliberately neutral between them; what matters is only that propositions have determinate presentational content, not which metaphysical theory of that content is correct.

Dodd defends a contemporary version of the identity theory in *An Identity Theory of Truth*, arguing that true propositions are identical with facts: the Fregean thought that p —when true—just is the fact that p . The present essay's position is related but distinct, and the distinction matters. Dodd operates at the level of individual truth-bearers: each true proposition is identified with a particular fact. This requires a prior ontology of facts as independently existing entities—items in the world with which propositions can be numerically identical. The question of what makes that identity hold, and what the nature of facts is, remains open; Dodd's theory does not eliminate the facts-ontology—it inherits and presupposes it. Facts must already be available as independently existing items for propositions to be numerically identical with them. $T \equiv R$ operates at a different level: it identifies truth as a property—the truth-property itself—with reality as such. There are no facts invoked as independent items, no matching between thought and world even at the individual level. Reality is not a collection of facts to which true propositions individually correspond or with which they are individually identical. Reality is the single domain of existence, and truth is that domain, not a relation to it or a coincidence within it. The identity is at the level of the truth-property, not the truth-bearer. This is why $T \equiv R$ eliminates the gap where Dodd's theory merely crosses it.

The full consequence of $T \equiv R$ at the level of truth-bearers is *propositional realism*: a true proposition does not point at a fact from outside it—it is a fact in propositional mode. The proposition and the fact are one item, not two items found to coincide. This is not an auxiliary commitment

added to answer objections; it is what numerical identity at the level of truth-bearers directly entails.

This statement exists.

Its existence and its reality are the same actuality. There is no criterion for being real beyond existing—reality is the totality of what exists, not a further realm that existence must satisfy. This essay operates within *actualism*: being and existence are coextensive; there are no subsistent non-existents, no Meinongian objects with ontological status but no actuality. This commitment is not derived from the falsity of correspondence; it is an independent metaphysical premise, supported on its own terms. The very notion of a subsistent non-existent requires a prior domain of existence within which subsistence is contrasted with actuality. Meinongian objects require existence as a prior contrast-class for their very intelligibility: to be a non-existent presupposes the category of existence in its own denial. The distinction between subsistence and actuality collapses on examination, because subsistence is intelligible only as a privation of actuality, not as an independent ontological mode. Actualism is the default of intelligibility, not a conclusion of this essay's argument. Given actualism, to exist is already to be real. The term *actuality* in what follows designates full self-identical existence—not merely possible or subsistent being, but existence that is wholly what it is.

If truth is identical with reality, then whatever exists as a propositional reality whose existence and presentational content coincide is true. Truth and falsity attach only within the domain of propositional reality: truth is not predicated of stones or sounds, which are real but not truth-apt; it is predicated of propositional structures, which are real as truth-bearers. This statement is a propositional reality; therefore it is true by the criterion it asserts. It requires no correspondence to verify, no system to cohere within, no utility to demonstrate, no consensus to achieve, no metalanguage to contain it. Its ground is existence, and existence is immediate—immediate in the precise sense that the question “what makes existence exist?” is not a well-formed question: it already presupposes existence in its asking, and thereby dissolves rather than invites an answer.

Any denial of this claim must itself exist as a propositional reality in order to bear the denial at all. What confirms existence as ground is not the physical instantiation of the denial (the sound wave, the neural firing) but the logical force it carries: existence as the ground of truth is inescapable not because every physical event confirms it but because every truth-apt act—including denial—is already an exercise of propositional existence.

A statement that survives self-application is *autological*. The Identity Theory is autological. Every other theory examined here is heterological: each, when pressed to satisfy its own criterion, fails to do so—by regress, dissolution, performative contradiction, or structural exclusion. The Identity Theory is the only autological theory of truth among these—and uniquely so: any theory that passes the autological criterion must ground the truth of its own claim in something that requires no external verification. The only candidate for such a ground is existence itself.

A primitivist might object that truth itself is self-grounding as a brute primitive, requiring no identification with existence. But a theory that merely designates truth as self-grounding without

explaining why no further ground is needed does not enact closure—it asserts it. The autological criterion is not satisfied by declaring self-evidence; it is satisfied by demonstrating that the question of external grounding does not arise. The primitivist must assert that truth is primitive. That assertion exists—it is a truth-apt act, a propositional reality in the sense defined above. For it to exist as a truth-bearing act, existence must already obtain: propositional reality presupposes existence as the prior condition on which any propositional structure rests. The primitivist might respond symmetrically: truth equally is a condition of any assertion being true, so truth is as prior as existence. But this symmetry fails. Existence is a condition of being—it is presupposed by any item whatever, prior to any question of truth or falsity. Truth is a property that attaches only to what already exists as a propositional reality; it is not a condition of existence but a predicate of existents. The asymmetry is structural: truth presupposes existence (to be true is, first, to exist as a proposition); existence does not presuppose truth. To exist as a stone or a sound requires no truth-predicate at all—such items are truth-indifferent. Even to exist as a propositional structure—a truth-bearer—requires no prior truth-predicate in order to exist; the propositional structure must exist before any question of its truth or falsity can arise. Therefore the primitivist’s own claim about truth already stands on existence, and truth cannot be more fundamental than the condition it stands on. The primitivist’s “truth is its own ground” must itself be grounded in existence or it is not a truth-bearing act at all. Grounded in existence, it collapses into $T \equiv R$. Not grounded, it fails the autological criterion on its own terms.

A theory that grounds truth in existence thereby identifies truth with reality—arriving at $T \equiv R$ as the unique structural expression of autological closure. Heterology is not a minor defect in the other theories. It is their verdict, issued by their own logic, on themselves.

$$\mathcal{T}_{\text{id}} \models_{\text{sat}} P_{\text{id}}(\mathcal{T}_{\text{id}}) \quad (\text{AC})$$

It does not pass the test from outside. It is the test, passing itself, from within.

VIII. Objections

$T \equiv R$ is trivially true and therefore uninformative.

The charge confuses semantic synonymy with ontological identity. If “truth” and “reality” were synonymous—if they meant the same—then $T \equiv R$ would be a tautology, as empty as “a bachelor is unmarried.” But the two terms arrive at their referent by entirely different routes: “truth” is a predicate applied to propositions; “reality” is the totality of what exists. That two terms with different senses and different grammatical functions turn out to designate one entity is not trivial; it is a substantive ontological discovery with consequences throughout philosophy. The claim that water is H_2O arrives at one entity by two routes—phenomenal and chemical—and the identity is not trivially true; it is empirically discovered and theoretically significant. The analogy is illustrative only:

water = H₂O is *a posteriori* necessary, arrived at through empirical inquiry. $T \equiv R$ is arrived at through logical pressure alone—the autological criterion eliminates every relational account, leaving identity as the structural residue. The analogy shows that identity claims with different-sensed terms are non-trivial; it does not imply that $T \equiv R$ is discovered the same way. $T \equiv R$ arrives at one entity by a propositional route and an existential route. The convergence is what dissolves the problems that haunted every relational theory. Tautologies dissolve nothing. This does.

The Identity Theory cannot account for false propositions.

Propositional realism, established in §VII, handles this directly. If a true proposition is a fact in propositional mode—one item, not a representation pointing at an external item—then a false proposition is a propositional structure whose identity-conditions are satisfied at the level of existence but not at the level of presentational coincidence: it exists as a mode of reality, but no propositional fact whose content is what that proposition presents exists—no fully self-identical propositional reality whose existence and presentational content coincide. The discrepancy is entirely internal to the proposition, not a failed match across a gap to an external world. There are not two items being compared—there is one propositional structure that does not fully realise its own identity as a proposition.

This differs from correspondence in structure, not vocabulary alone. Correspondence requires two ontologically independent items (proposition; fact) and a tertiary relation (matching) between them. The Identity account requires one item—the proposition as a mode of reality—whose own internal identity-conditions may be fully or only partially realised. No external world is consulted, no gap is crossed, no relation is invoked. Falsehood is incomplete propositional self-identity. The charge that this covertly reinstates correspondence misreads the structure: the discrepancy in a false proposition is between its two internal aspects—existence and presentation—not between itself and something outside it. No gap reopens, because none was posited.

The self-application test is not itself self-applying.

The test claims: any viable theory of truth must be true by its own criterion. Does this claim satisfy its own criterion? The claim exists as a propositional reality—a truth-apt content individuated by what it presents. Whatever exists is real. If truth is reality, the claim is true by the Identity criterion. The test demands self-application and enacts it. A criterion that does so has answered the objection by being the answer.

IX. The Meta-Level Collapses

If $T \equiv R$, what makes the Identity Theory itself true? Is there a meta-truth above it, regenerating the regress?

The question assumes a gap. The Identity Theory is not a claim about reality posited as external to it; it is the structure of reality, disclosed in a proposition. The meta-question presupposes that the truth of $T \equiv R$ is a separate fact above $T \equiv R$ —but if truth is reality, the truth of this statement just

is its existence as a propositional reality—its existence is its reality, and truth is reality. No separate meta-level is needed because the truth of $T \equiv R$ and $T \equiv R$ itself are one and the same item.

$$T(T) \equiv T$$

The derivation is direct. If $T \equiv R$, then the truth of the claim “ $T \equiv R$ ” is its reality; its reality is its existence; its existence just is $T \equiv R$ itself. Therefore $T(T \equiv R) \equiv T \equiv R$, which is $T(T) \equiv T$: truth applied to the Identity Theory yields the Identity Theory, not a level above it. Truth is reflexive at every level because truth is existence, and existence does not transcend itself. $T \equiv R$ does not require a higher floor, because its truth is not established from above—it is its existence, which is immediate. For Tarski, a new metalanguage is always required because no language can contain its own truth predicate. The Identity Theory eliminates the gap at the first level. Reality does not require a ground external to itself: to seek a ground for existence is already to presuppose existence—the question dissolves rather than receives an answer. This is not a claim about what reality positively is; it is the recognition that the demand for an external ground is self-undermining.

Conclusion

The demand was not imposed on the theories examined here. It was extracted from them—from what it means to claim that one knows what truth is.

Six theories failed. The failures are not separate accidents. They are one failure in six forms: each cannot satisfy the criterion it proposes as truth. Correspondence. Coherence. Pragmatism. Consensus. Deflationism. Tarski.

The Identity Theory does not require anything beyond itself; it is already what it seeks. A true statement does not correspond to reality—it is real. Its existence is already its truth. No external relation is needed: there are not two things to relate.

This essay is itself the proof. It exists. If truth is reality, then this essay—these sentences, this argument, this demonstration—is true by the criterion it advances. The essay does not argue for $T \equiv R$ from outside. The essay *is* $T \equiv R$ in operation: reality self-disclosed in writing, confirming its own criterion by satisfying it.

The ancient question—what is truth?—was never only a question about language or correspondence. It was always a question about what is. The answer was always true: reality is. Truth is reality, self-disclosed. This essay is one instance of that disclosure. The door is not opened here—it was never closed.

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